Rabbit Hole

By David Lindsay-Abaire

Suggested Roles: *ACTOR: Howie*
ACTRESS: Becca, Danny's voice, TV Voice over (Tornadoes)

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Eight months ago, in a happy suburban home, the family dog darted out of the front yard*
ACTRESS: *And Danny followed - right into the path of an oncoming car.*
ACTOR: *It was an "accident,"*
ACTRESS: *But that just means that no one is to blame but everyone feels guilty.*
ACTOR: *The journey through grief is different for all of us . . .*
ACTRESS: *We each take our own path. There is no right or wrong way to grieve.*
TOGETHER: *Rabbit Hole by David Lindsay-Abaire*

HOWIE: **(Pg 14)** You want more wine?

BECCA: No, I've had two already.

HOWIE: Half a glass . . . *(he empties the rest into her glass and lowers the lights in the room)*

BECCA: What are you doing?

HOWIE: My eyes are sore, staring at that computer all day.

BECCA: **(Pg 15-18)** How was squash?

HOWIE: Good. I lost but it was good

BECCA: How's Rick? . . . . and Debbie? Did Rick mention her?

HOWIE: You can call her, you know. You can call Debbie.

BECCA: I don't wanna call her. She should call me.

HOWIE: She's uncomfortable, Bec. If she hasn't called you, it's because she doesn't know what to say.

BECCA: How about "Hey, Becca, how you doing? Haven't seen you in a while. I would've been there for her if God forbid something had ever happened to Robbie or Em. I wouldn't have vanished the way she did.

HOWIE: If you're pissed, you should call her and tell her . . . Okay, let it go.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

BECCA: Let what go?

HOWIE: Whatever's making you tense. You should try to relax a little. *(He moves to massage her shoulders and starts to kiss her neck)*

BECCA: What are you doing?

HOWIE: I'm trying to relax you – something wrong with that?

BECCA: I see what this is. Dimming the lights . . . plying me with liquor . . . . You're trying to seduce me.

HOWIE: Am I? *(moves in again romantically)*

BECCA: Alright, Romeo *(pushes him away)* Enough.

HOWIE: Jesus, Bec . . . it's been almost eight months. *(Beat)*

BECCA: I'm just not ready yet, Howie. I'm sorry if you think that's abnormal.

HOWIE: I thought it was nice. That's all. I was trying to make things nice.

BECCA: Well . . . you can't. I'm sorry, but things aren't "nice" anymore.

HOWIE: **(Pg 19-20)** -- then . . . maybe we should try again. *(Beat)*

BECCA: Oh for godsakes, Howie . . . Is that . . . Is ***that*** what this was?

HOWIE: No. No, of course not. It just . . . it might be something to talk about at some point.

BECCA: I . . . I can't. I'm sorry. I can't have that talk. *(Becca exits, Howie watches her go, then goes to the TV cabinet and pulls out a videotape and pops it in.)*

VOICE OF DANNY: Did you see me, Daddy?

HOWIE: *(speaks along with the video)* I did.

VOICE OF DANNY: No, you didn't. I'm invisible. I have magic.

HOWIE: *(speaks along with the video)* Down, Taz . . . Oh, I didn't realize. *(lights fade)*

********** A few weeks later*************

(Howie clicks on the TV and hits play on the VCR. We hear a documentary on tornadoes playing. [ ] words in red are not printed in the original script)

NEWS REPORTER: [Last year was the strongest storm season in a decade . . .] *(Howie is confused. Something isn't right. He ejects the tape, examines it, puts it back in and hits play again* [An F5 Tornado is the most damaging wind force]

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

HOWIE: **(Pg 32-34)** What is this? Becca? Becca!?!! *(Becca enters – Howie is beside himself)*

BECCA: What's the matter?

HOWIE: The ***television***. What ***is*** this?

BECCA: *(Looks to TV)* It's the Discovery Channel. The tornado program. I recorded it for you. What's the matter?

HOWIE: It's Danny's tape. You recorded over Danny's tape. Jesus, Becca! It's the only copy!

BECCA: Well, I didn't do it on purpose. *(Howie looks at her skeptically)* You think I recorded over Danny's tape on purpose?

HOWIE: You took the paintings off the fridge. Danny's paintings. And shoved them in a box.

BECCA: For safekeeping

HOWIE: You're trying to get rid of him. I'm sorry, but that's how it feels to me sometimes. Every day, it's something else. It feels like you're trying to get rid of any evidence he was ever here.

BECCA: *(It's as if she's been slapped)* The paintings are downstairs. In a box. You can look at them whenever you want.

HOWIE: The clothes. His shoes.

BECCA: We don't need all that stuff. Why would we keep –

HOWIE: Taz. Sending Taz to your mother's!

BECCA: There was a lot going on, Howie. We couldn't deal with the dog.

HOWIE: If I hadn't bought the dog –

BECCA: And if ***I*** hadn't run inside to get the phone, or if ***I*** had latched the gate –

HOWIE: ***I*** left the gate unlatched!

BECCA: Well, ***I*** didn't check it. *(Retreats a bit)* I'm not playing this game again, Howie. It was no one's fault

HOWIE: Not even the dog's . . . Dogs chase squirrels. Boys chase dogs.

BECCA: Are you telling me or yourself?

HOWIE: He ***loved*** that dog! . . . And you got rid of him!

BECCA: Right, like I got rid of the tape. I get it.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

HOWIE: He was a reminder.

BECCA: Yes, he was a reminder. So what? I wanted one less reminder around here. **(Pg 19)** I can't move without – I mean, Jesus, look at this. *(grabs a toy from the shelf)* ***Everywhere.*** *(grabs a kid's book from a stack of magazines)* Here: ***"Runaway Bunny"*** for godsake. The puzzles. The smudgy fingerprints on the doorjambs.

HOWIE: I like seeing his fingerprints.

BECCA: Because you don't have to sit and stare at them day in and day out. You get to escape. You get to go to work. . . . I left all that to be a mom.

HOWIE: **(Pg 18-19)** *(after a pause)* I think you should see someone. *(Beat)* I know you're not one for therapists, but I think you should. We could go together if that's help. Or maybe you could try the group again.

BECCA: No. **(Pg 29)** A room full of God-freaks.

HOWIE: They're not God-freaks.

BECCA: Most of them ***are***, Howie. That's all they talk about. God's plan. My favorite is "God needed another angel." What is ***that***? He's ***God***! Why can't he just ***make*** another angel? It pisses me off. Trying to find some ridiculous meaning in – "Hey look, I stepped in shit, it must be part of God's plan." How nice they all have something that makes them feel a little better. Like I don't feel bad enough. I've gotta go and have ***that*** rubbed in my face? [God's] a sadistic prick.

HOWIE: **(Pg 34-35)** *(long silence)* You have to stop erasing him! I'm not [just] talking about the tape, Becca! It's Tax, and the paintings, and the clothes and it's ***everything***! You HAVE - TO - STOP!

BECCA: Do you really not know me, Howie? Do you really not know how utterly impossible that would be? To erase him? No matter how many things I give to charity, do you really think I don't see him every second of every day? That tape was an accident. And believe me, I will beat myself up about it forever. Like everything else that I could've prevented but didn't.

HOWIE: That's not what I want, Bec. It's not what I'm talking about.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

BECCA: No? Because it feels like it is. It feels like I don't feel bad enough for you. I'm not mourning in the right ***way***. But let me just say, Howie, that I am mourning as much as you are. And my grief is just as real and awful as yours.

HOWIE: I know that.

BECCA: You're not in a better place than I am, you're just in a ***different*** place. And that sucks that we can't be there for each other right now, but that's just the way it is.

HOWIE: His stuff is all we have left. That's all I'm saying. And every bit of it you get rid of –

BECCA: I understand that. You don't wanna let go of it. I understand, Howie.

HOWIE: Do you? ***Do*** you? *(No response)* Something has to change here. Because I can't do this . . . like this. It's too hard. *(Beat)* it's too hard. *(Howie exits, leaving Becca alone.)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: David Lindsay-Abaire
ISBN: 978-1559362900
Publisher: Theatre Communications
Date (Month/Year): Sept 2006

AWARD HISTORY

2007 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
NIETOC
CA State Qualifier
IL State Finalist
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY